Alaska Senate Fight Centers on Two Candidates Named Dan Sullivan

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President Donald Trump says he ordered a lawsuit that could block **certification** of Alaska's Senate election, but only if the Republican **incumbent** loses. The case, filed by the Justice Department close to Election Day, centers on a ballot with two candidates named Dan Sullivan.

The **incumbent** is Republican Senator Dan Sullivan, listed as Daniel S. The other candidate is Dan J. Sullivan. Republicans are worried voters could get confused by the similar names. The Alaska Supreme Court has already considered the question and said Dan J. Sullivan could stay on the ballot.

The Justice Department says it filed the lawsuit to protect the **integrity** of the Senate election. It argued that the federal government could be harmed if **certification** were tainted by what it called a **frivolous** candidacy, because that would undermine confidence in the federal government.

President Trump, asked about the case, said he was the one who said to file it. He argued that Democrats had put up a second Dan Sullivan, and he called Daniel J. the fake candidate. The report notes that Daniel J. Sullivan has voted in Alaska races before.

Election expert David Becker, a former Justice Department civil rights attorney, offered a different view. He said the matter is purely one of state law, and that the Justice Department has no authority and no role in it. He also said trying to block **certification** 11 days before the vote was **unprecedented**.

The Alaska dispute is part of a final campaign push as Trump works to help Republicans keep control of Congress. Trump is scheduled to campaign in Georgia on Saturday and in Michigan on Sunday, where Republican Mike Rogers faces Democrat Abdul El-Sayed. Former President Barack Obama is also scheduled to campaign in Michigan on Saturday with El-Sayed.

Word Treasure

certification -- The official act of confirming that an election result is valid.

incumbent -- A person who already holds a political job and is running to keep it.

integrity -- Honesty and trustworthiness, so people can believe the result is fair.

frivolous -- Something with little real value or importance, not meant to be taken seriously.

unprecedented -- Something that has never happened before.

Background you need

A Senate election chooses who will represent a state in the United States Senate.

Voters pick from the names printed on a ballot, so two candidates with very similar names can cause confusion.

Certification is the official step that confirms an election result.

Questions about who may appear on a state ballot are usually decided under state law, and state courts can rule on them.

Break it down

LEAD: Trump says he ordered a lawsuit over Alaska's Senate election
KEY EVENT: The Justice Department case could block certification if the incumbent loses
+- WHO: Republican Senator Dan Sullivan, listed as Daniel S., and Dan J. Sullivan
+- WHY: Republicans worry voters could confuse the two similar names
+- COURT: The Alaska Supreme Court said Dan J. Sullivan could stay on the ballot
ARGUMENT FOR THE CASE: The Justice Department says it aims to protect the election's integrity
COUNTERVIEW: David Becker says it is purely state law and the department has no role
CONTEXT: The dispute comes as Trump campaigns to help Republicans keep control of Congress

Why it matters

The case raises questions about who decides ballot disputes and whether a result can be certified, which affects trust in elections and control of Congress.

Test what you remember

1. According to President Trump, what could the lawsuit block?

- (A) The Alaska Supreme Court's ruling
- (B) Certification of Alaska's Senate election if the Republican incumbent loses
- (C) Voting in Georgia
- (D) Campaign events in Michigan

2. How is the incumbent listed on the ballot?

- (A) Mike Rogers
- (B) Dan J. Sullivan
- (C) David Becker
- (D) Daniel S.

3. What has the Alaska Supreme Court already said about Dan J. Sullivan?

- (A) He must leave the ballot
- (B) Dan J. Sullivan could stay on the ballot
- (C) He is the Republican incumbent
- (D) He has never voted in Alaska

4. Why does the Justice Department say it filed the lawsuit?

- (A) To remove the incumbent from office
- (B) To protect the integrity of the Senate election
- (C) To help a campaign in Michigan
- (D) To delay voting in Georgia

5. What did election expert David Becker say about the Justice Department's role?

- (A) It should campaign for the incumbent
- (B) It has no authority and no role in the matter
- (C) It should run Alaska's elections
- (D) It ordered the Alaska Supreme Court to act

6. Where is President Trump scheduled to campaign on Sunday?

- (A) Michigan
- (B) Arizona
- (C) Alaska
- (D) Georgia

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The Justice Department: Says it filed the lawsuit to protect the integrity of the Senate election, arguing the federal government could be harmed if certification were tainted by what it called a frivolous candidacy.

2. President Donald Trump: Says he ordered the filing, argues Democrats put up a second Dan Sullivan, and calls Daniel J. the fake candidate.

3. Election expert David Becker: Says the matter is purely one of state law, that the Justice Department has no authority and no role in it, and that trying to block certification 11 days before the vote was unprecedented.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):